

film on the effects of drought in the Southeast. The traders on the long side of wheat looked very happy.

At the security check near the entrance to the trading floor, I was met by John Sullivan, badge 537, Lind-Waldock's man over here.

I think Mr. Sullivan had been warned that an eccentric Lind-Waldock client was coming over to follow his own corn trade around the room. He tried to be as nice about it as possible, even after I told him I wanted to "sell one September 170" and then asked what it meant. Mr. Sullivan patiently explained that I was selling one corn contract, representing 5,000 bushels, to somebody else for \$170 a bushel. Hopefully, I could buy it back cheaper before the contract expired in September, or else I'd have to come up with extra money or with the corn.

He escorted me onto the trading floor, and over to the corn pit to meet with Lind-Waldock's corn person, Marty Dickman.

"Beans are rallying," somebody yelled. There were so many shouts from the adjacent bean pit I had to lean far into the corn pit to hear what my corn bidder was saying. "Don't stand in the pit, stand back," Mr. Sullivan admonished, grabbing me by the sweater. I stood back while Mr. Dickman wiggled his fingers at twenty or so companions until one had bought my corn.

Mr. Sullivan informed me I'd sold my 5,000 bushels to Cargill, one of the biggest agricultural conglomerates in the Midwest! This was my second great thrill of the day. Selling this much corn made me think of my mother, struggling in her summer garden. Here I was in Chicago, having always refused to help my mother with watering and especially with weeding, getting paid for more bushels of my own corn than she could grow in a lifetime, and doing business with a giant in the industry. It goes to show that farming doesn't have to be drudgery, if you do it the modern way.

My elation was short-lived. Perhaps Mr. Dickman, the corn trader, had seen me smile. Anyway, he had some rather negative things to say, which I wrote down as follows:

"When I first came down here, I was Mr. Big Ego. I had a law degree and here were all these ex-cops and truck drivers and people with 200-word vocabularies trading in the pits. I figured I'd make a killing, right? With this competition, how could you lose? Then